

An immense crowd of spectators, including leading members of Calcutta society, gathered on both sides of the Hooghly river, on Saturday, 3 February 1855. They were there to watch as the first train to Raneegunge made its inaugural run from the Howrah station. A select group of guests were guided past a decorated arcade, festooned with flowers and evergreens, to the river bank, where they boarded two steam ferries hired specially by the railway company for the occasion. The ferries took the guests to the other side of the bank, from where they made their way to the railway station.

At precisely 9am, Governor-General Lord Dalhousie and his staff arrived. He was, however, unwell and so inspected only the arrangements and flagged off the train after a 19-gun salute. He did not board the special train, with 15 carriages, which left Howrah at 9.40am after the reading of prayers by the Lord Bishop of Calcutta.

The fire chariot

The train crossed a distance of 193 km, weaving its way through brightly decorated stations and curious villagers waiting to get a glimpse of the majestic fire-belching leviathan.

The following day, a newspaper described the excitement created by the event: "To ignorant natives who understand nothing of the means by which the *Aag ka Gahrie*, or fire chariot, is moved, few things could have been more astounding or more convincing of the miraculous power possessed by the English. One curious explanation was that the locomotive was made to go simply by the '*Hookum* or order of Lord Dalhousie'!"

The festivities continued after the train reached Burdwan at 12.30pm, where it stopped for three hours for some much-needed breakfast. "The entire party, without the slightest delay, all evidently in the best possible appetite, partook of the repast, scarcely waiting till the Bishop, had breathed a prayer over it," a correspondent for the *Calcutta Papers* reported. Toasts followed, including one by EIR agent, Rowland McDonald Stephenson, the engineer who had pushed for the development of the railway line system in Bengal.